

EXPERIMENT E.V. · APPLICATION PORTAL INVESTIGATION

Revised Investigation Report

Missing Application Cases

Prepared 21 August 2026 · Revision supersedes the initial report

Cases reviewed: Jonathan Nelio Eilert; Thea Sitte

Purpose: establish the evidence for account/application loss, account attribution, recovery, and wider impact

Scope: WordPress audit records, Gravity Forms data, user metadata, database schema, and UpdraftPlus backup logs

Key outcome: Jonathan's account deletion is confirmed. The deletion is not proof that an application was deleted. Thea's live, recoverable draft proves that application state can be missing from the portal without a user-account deletion.

1. Executive Summary

The investigation confirms that Jonathan Nelio Eilert's WordPress account existed and was deleted by a browser session authenticated as Effecticore_Maintenance. The available WordPress logs do not identify the individual person behind that shared account and do not preserve the initiating request, session identifier, bulk-action context, or plugin/script name.

Jonathan deletion: user ID 40372 was deleted on **20 August 2026, 06:25:46.298 UTC** (08:25:46.298 CEST) by the Effecticore_Maintenance account (ID 34066), from 187.14.255.7, macOS 10.15.7 / Chrome 151.

A full database backup completed about 1 minute 50 seconds before this deletion and was successfully uploaded to Google Drive. It is the authoritative recovery source for Jonathan's pre-deletion state.

A second case, Thea Sitte, establishes a related but distinct failure mode: her user account remains active, no final Gravity Forms entry exists, but a recoverable 3,427-byte Save-and-Continue draft for the Canada application remains in the database.

2. Evidentiary Limits

Question	Assessment
Who physically used Effecticore_Maintenance?	NOT IDENTIFIABLE The logs contain only a shared username, IP, browser/device fingerprint, and timestamp.
Does the audit entry prove a person clicked "Delete user"?	NO It proves a deletion occurred under an authenticated browser session. A browser-driven plugin or automation could emit the same event.
Was Jonathan's application deleted with the user?	NOT PROVEN No database foreign-key cascade exists. A custom hook or separate process would be required.
Can Jonathan's data be recovered?	LIKELY A pre-deletion database backup exists remotely.
Is there evidence of a wider application workflow issue?	YES Thea's surviving account has an active draft but no final application entry.

3. Jonathan Nelio Eilert

3.1 Account lifecycle

UTC time	Finding
05 Aug 2026, 12:07:09–12:07:11	Unauthenticated frontend flow from 92.209.222.83 set display name to Jonathan Eilert and added the Subscriber role. Audit metadata records CurrentUserID=0.
07 Aug 2026, 11:55:40	Failed login from the same IP/browser family.
20 Aug 2026, 06:17:21.629	Effecticore_Maintenance login from 187.14.255.7.
20 Aug 2026, 06:25:46.298	Account deleted ; target user ID 40372, username jonathaneilert, subscriber role.

3.2 Maintenance-session analysis

The maintenance account login contained only LoginPageURL=https://web-maintenance.effecticore.de/. No audit metadata field contains a session ID, an individual staff identity, a request URI for the deletion, or a plugin/script identifier.

The event sequence shows an authenticated browser session: login; language/system update; several post changes; user deletion; further post changes. Server-originated WordPress loopback requests (85.13.154.109, WordPress/7.0.4) are attributable to internal scrape/health requests and do not identify a second operator.

The evidence supports an authenticated maintenance-session action. It does not establish whether it was a direct WordPress UI deletion, a bulk operation, or automation started from that browser session.

3.3 Application state in the live database

No live record was found for Jonathan in the final Gravity Forms entry table, draft-submission table, started-entry table, ZIP export table, email-log table, WordPress posts, post metadata, or multisite signup table. The custom saw* tables are programme lookup tables only and do not store applicants.

No foreign key references the WordPress users table, so MySQL could not automatically cascade the user deletion into application data.

3.4 Recovery source

Pre-deletion backup confirmed. UpdraftPlus began a database-only backup at 06:22:32 UTC on 20 August. Its database dump finished at approximately 06:23:56 UTC, before Jonathan's deletion, and was uploaded successfully to Google Drive.

backup_2026-08-20-0822_Experiment_Deine_Austauschorga_73a85b8efed0-db.gz

The archive contains 198 database tables. It must be restored only to an isolated staging database. Search the staged users, usermeta, gf_entry, gf_entry_meta, and gf_draft_submissions tables for user ID 40372 and

Jonathan’s identifiers. In particular, inspect any gpasc-resume-tokens- * metadata before concluding that no draft existed.

4. Thea Sitte

4.1 Confirmed current state

Item	Evidence
User account	Active/approved subscriber, user ID 40375; account created 05 Aug 2026.
Application route	Canada route /exp-portal/saw-27-28/?program_country=Kanada.
Application form	Gravity Forms Form 179: <i>Bewerbung Schüleraustausch weltweit 2027/28</i> .
Final submission	NOT FOUND No final Form 179 entry is associated with user ID 40375.
Saved draft	FOUND A Form 179 Save-and-Continue draft exists, created 17 Aug 2026 13:06:47 UTC, with 3,427 bytes of submission data.

Thea’s account contains a Form 179 started-entry marker and a Save-and-Continue association. The saved draft should be exported/preserved before any user-facing test is performed. Do not expose or circulate its resume token, session token, nonce, CAPTCHA token, or draft contents.

4.2 Interpretation

Thea’s case is not explained by deletion of her WordPress account: the account remains active. The evidence instead shows a saved draft that was never persisted as a final entry. The reported confirmation email requires independent verification in the transactional mail provider, because the site’s local email-log table has no matching record.

The two cases therefore point to a broader application-state/persistence issue. A user can have no visible final application even when an account remains active; Jonathan’s account deletion may be consequential, but it is not sufficient to explain this pattern.

4.3 Later administrative-context access

On 21 Aug 2026 at 11:23:44.724 UTC, Thea’s account was logged in from 89.63.10.143 with a Windows/Chrome browser. The recorded login URL was a WordPress administrator Users search page for the account email. This is consistent with administrative “login as user”/impersonation access, not an ordinary applicant login. The audit record does not capture the original administrator who initiated it.

5. Other Deleted Applicants

The audit log contains multiple deleted applicant accounts during August 2026, involving both shared/known actors and “Unknown User” records. This establishes that Jonathan’s deletion was not the only user deletion in the period. It does not establish that every deletion was erroneous or that every deleted user had an application.

A wider impact review should reconcile each deleted account with its final entries, drafts, started-entry records, and confirmation-email evidence before communicating totals or root cause.

6. Root-Cause Assessment

Hypothesis	Assessment
Jonathan was deleted manually in the maintenance UI	POSSIBLE Browser-authenticated session supports it; audit data lacks the deletion request.
Jonathan was deleted by scheduled cron	NOT ESTABLISHED A daily exp_delete_unverified_users hook exists, but no active implementation was found and its nominal schedule did not align with the deletion time.
Jonathan was deleted by database cascade	EXCLUDED No database foreign-key relationship exists.
Application finalization/persistence defect	SUPPORTED Thea has a live draft but no final entry; Jonathan has no live final entry.
Confirmation sent despite no final entry	UNVERIFIED Confirm against Brevo/Mailin transaction logs and Gravity Forms notification configuration.

7. Required Actions

1. Preserve/export Thea's draft, without exposing tokens or submission content.
2. Download the pre-deletion Google Drive database backup and restore it only to staging.
3. Recover Jonathan's pre-deletion data from staging and determine whether a final entry or resumable draft existed.
4. Obtain web-server and maintenance-system logs for 20 Aug 2026 06:17–06:30 UTC to attribute the shared-account session; WordPress logs are insufficient for this.
5. Review the form-179 final-submit path, Save-and-Continue handling, notification trigger order, and error handling.
6. Reconcile all August deleted accounts against application/draft records before declaring a wider incident scope.
7. Replace the shared maintenance account with named, individual accounts and require MFA/audit correlation.

8. Client-Safe Conclusion

Jonathan's account was deleted on 20 August 2026 at 08:25:46 CEST by a browser session authenticated as the shared Effecticore_Maintenance account. The available records do not identify the individual user or prove whether the deletion was a direct manual click or browser-initiated automation. A full database backup from immediately before the deletion is available for safe staging recovery.

Thea's account remains active, but her Canada application exists only as a recoverable draft and not as a final entry. This demonstrates that missing application data can occur independently of user-account deletion and requires a focused review of the application finalization and notification workflow.